something his parents approved of, as Yash recalled in an interview to India Today TV in April. "If you come back, never ever think of anything else...just study and then go get a job," was the parting message. "I said fine, but give me one chance...I'll go and do something. They thought I'll come back soon, but that never happened."

The sequence of events didn't quite play out too smoothly. Appearing on the popular Kannada celebrity talk show *Weekend with Ramesh* in August 2014, Yash recounted his phase of struggle, including a night on the platform at the Majestic bus terminal while contemplating taking the bus back to Mysore before finally deciding to brazen it out. The perseverance paid off after he landed a role in the television serial *Nanda Gokula*, and a second one followed soon after. The daily wage went up from Rs 500 to Rs 1,500, which he liberally spent on new outfits, more so than fellow television actors who, in those days, had to manage their own wardrobes. His gaze, as he puts it, was firmly on eventual stardom. After acting stints in four TV serials, Yash made his silver screen debut in 2007 with a small role in romance drama *Jambada Hudugi*. His first film in a lead role, titled *Rocky*, bombed at the box office. The name, however, stuck on, and he became a 'Rocking Star' for his fans.

Filmmaker Suman Kittur, who cast Yash in his second lead role in the political satire *Kallara Santhe* (2009), recalls a bright youngster in his early 20s who was very clear about his goals in life. His priorities back then were his sister's college education, her marriage, buying a house after his own marriage. "He planned everything and saw it through," she says. It was in his debut TV show that Yash first worked alongside Radhika Pandit, who would be his leading lady in four films and eventually his wife in 2016.

The confidence and street cred that Rocky personifies in KGF films is an intrinsic part of Yash's personality too. "*Naavu* class *alla*...mass (I'm not class, I'm mass)", he says in the 2014 Kannada blockbuster *Mr & Mrs Ramachari*. Perhaps there's a dash of Rajinikanth in there—and more than just in the dialogue delivery. Filmmaker Shashank, who cast Yash in *Moggina Manasu* (2008), the film that first won him recognition, recalls conversations where both shared their exasperation over Kannada cinema's inability to break out and compete on a bigger scale like neighbouring Tamil and Telugu films. "He was waiting for an opportunity," says Shashank. "When he found the right team, he ventured into that effort. He was destined for that." Yash was floored by Prashant Neel's gangster flick *Ugramm* (2014) and the idea of *KGF* began taking shape when production house Hombale Films brought the two together. When the Part 1 came out in 2018, it

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Release: December 2022

